

BEGC-102

European Classical Literature

Assignment - July 2025, and January 2026 Sessions

(Based on Blocks 1 - 4)

Max. Marks: 100

Answer all questions.

Section A

1. Write short notes in about 100 words each: $2 \times 5 = 10$

(i) Iliad

The *Iliad*, attributed to Homer, is an epic poem centred on the Trojan War and, more specifically, on the anger of Achilles. It presents the conflict between Achilles and Agamemnon, the battles between Greeks and Trojans, and the intervention of the gods. Honour, heroism, fate, pride, friendship and mortality are major themes. Achilles is the greatest warrior, but his anger has serious consequences for the Greek army. The poem also humanises the enemy, especially through Hector and Priam. Thus, the *Iliad* is not merely a war narrative; it explores the costs of heroic ambition and the vulnerability of human life.

(ii) Roman Comedy

Roman comedy developed largely from Greek New Comedy but acquired distinct Roman features. Plautus and Terence are its best-known representatives. Typical Roman comedies use mistaken identities, clever servants, young lovers, strict fathers, greedy characters and complicated plots involving deception and recognition. *The Pot of Gold* by Plautus is a major example. Roman comedy often creates humour through exaggerated characters, misunderstandings, wordplay and situations that are gradually resolved. The plays were designed primarily to entertain, but they also reveal aspects of Roman family life, social relationships and attitudes towards money and marriage.

2. Reference to the Context in about 100 words each: $2 \times 5 = 10$

(i) "...Here, as Pentheus profanely spied on the sacred rituals,
Who saw him first? Who rushed on him first in maniacal frenzy?
And who first launched her thyrsus to savage her own dear son?
His mother Agave: 'watch me, sisters,' she shouted, 'both of you.'
Look at this huge wild boar there wandering over our meadow."

Reference to the Context: The passage is from Euripides' *The Bacchae*. Pentheus, king of Thebes, challenges the worship of Dionysus and secretly observes the sacred rites. Under Dionysian madness, the women mistake him for a wild animal and attack him. Agave, his own mother, does not recognise him. The passage therefore shows the tragic reversal of normal family affection and the destructive power of divine frenzy. It also illustrates the central conflict between Pentheus' refusal to acknowledge Dionysus and the god's power over human beings.

(ii) "The family I have now protected for year...
He left behind a son, the one who lives here now,
And he's as bad as dad and granddad were before,
And yet his only daughter daily worships me."

Reference to the Context: These lines are spoken by Lar Familiaris in Plautus' *The Pot of Gold*. The household spirit explains that he has protected the family because an ancestor honoured him. The present head of the family, however, has inherited greed and selfishness. His daughter Phaedria is different because she continues to worship the household spirit. The passage establishes the contrast between greed and piety and helps explain why Lar Familiaris takes an interest in Phaedria's future. It also introduces the domestic and comic conflict that drives the play.

Section B

Answer the following in about 350 words each: $4 \times 20 = 80$

1. Do you agree with Plato's criticism that the *Iliad* offers no morals? Give a detailed answer.

Plato's criticism of epic poetry is connected with his larger concern about the moral influence of literature. In *The Republic*, Plato is suspicious of poetry that presents gods and heroes behaving badly because he fears that such representations may encourage undesirable conduct. From this perspective, the *Iliad* can appear morally problematic: its world contains anger, violence, revenge, pride, deception and conflicts among gods and human beings. Achilles' anger, for example, brings suffering to the Greek army, while the gods frequently behave in ways that do not resemble ideal moral models.

However, it would be too simple to conclude that the *Iliad* has no moral dimension. The poem repeatedly shows the consequences of destructive emotions. Achilles' rage causes enormous loss, and his treatment of Hector's body becomes an extreme expression of grief and revenge. Yet Achilles eventually changes when Priam comes to ask for Hector's body. Priam's suffering reminds Achilles of his own father, Peleus, and Achilles responds with pity. This movement from rage towards compassion is one of the poem's important human lessons.

The poem also presents Hector as a figure of responsibility. He fights not merely for personal glory but for Troy, his family and his community. His farewell to Andromache reveals the emotional cost of heroic duty. Similarly, the meeting between Achilles and Priam emphasises the shared humanity of enemies. Both men are vulnerable to grief and death.

Therefore, the *Iliad* does not offer morality as a simple list of rules. Its moral meaning emerges through the consequences of pride, anger, violence, honour and compassion. Plato's concern about the influence of poetic representation is understandable within his philosophical argument, but the epic can also be read as a complex exploration of moral choices and their consequences. Its lessons are indirect and dramatic rather than explicitly didactic.

2. Examine *Oedipus Rex* as a Greek Tragedy.

Oedipus Rex by Sophocles is one of the clearest examples of Greek tragedy. It presents a serious conflict in which Oedipus, king of Thebes, attempts to discover the cause of the plague affecting his city. The search gradually reveals a terrible truth: he has unknowingly killed his father, Laius, and married his mother, Jocasta. Thus the investigation intended to save Thebes becomes the means by which Oedipus discovers his own past.

The play contains several central features of Greek tragedy. Fate is crucial because the prophecy concerning Oedipus is fulfilled despite attempts to avoid it. At the same time, Oedipus is not passive. His determination to discover the truth and his confidence in his judgement contribute to the unfolding tragedy. His tragic movement is therefore connected with both destiny and human action.

Recognition, or *anagnorisis*, is another major feature. Oedipus gradually understands that the murderer he is searching for is himself. This produces a reversal of fortune, or *peripeteia*: the respected king becomes a ruined and self-blinded man. Jocasta's death and Oedipus' self-blinding intensify the tragic effect. The chorus reflects the fears and religious assumptions of Theban society and comments on the events.

Ultimately, *Oedipus Rex* is a Greek tragedy because it combines fate, human error, recognition, reversal, suffering and moral reflection. Its lasting power comes from the conflict between the human desire to know the truth and the painful consequences of discovering it.

3. Would you agree that *The Pot of Gold* is a comedy? Discuss, keeping in mind the *dramatis personae* of *Lar Familiaris*.

The Pot of Gold by Plautus is a Roman comedy built around money, family relationships, secrecy, misunderstanding and the possibility of marriage. Lar Familiaris, the household spirit, acts as a narrator and guardian. He explains the history of the hidden pot of gold and his special concern for Phaedria, the daughter of the miser Euclio.

Euclio is one of the central comic figures. His extreme fear of losing the gold makes him suspicious of everyone around him. His greed is exaggerated to the point of absurdity, creating much of the humour. Characters such as Megadorus, Lyconides, Staphyla and the cook contribute to the misunderstandings and movement of the plot. The marriage question also creates a conventional comic conflict between family expectations and young love.

The title object—the pot of gold—is a typical comic device. It produces secrecy, fear and confusion. Euclio's attempts to hide it make ordinary situations appear dangerous, while other characters interpret his behaviour differently. The audience knows more than several characters, and this dramatic irony creates humour. Plautus also uses exaggerated speech, situations and character types associated with Roman comedy.

Thus, *The Pot of Gold* clearly works as a comedy. Its comic effect arises from greed, misunderstanding, dramatic irony, exaggerated characterisation and the movement towards social reconciliation. *Lar Familiaris* helps establish the domestic and religious background of the plot from the beginning.

4. Discuss the relationship between Horace and his father based on “Satire 1:4”.

In “Satire 1:4”, Horace discusses satire, poetic criticism and the values that shaped his character. His father is especially important because Horace presents him as an early influence on his moral education. Rather than giving his son an education based only on social status or conventional ambition, Horace's father teaches him through observation of human behaviour and practical moral lessons.

Horace explains that his father warned him against harmful qualities by showing him examples from everyday life. If he saw a person behaving foolishly or dishonestly, he used that example to teach his son what should be avoided. In this sense, the father acts as a moral guide. He does not merely issue abstract rules; he encourages Horace to examine the consequences of different kinds of behaviour.

The relationship also contains affection and respect. Horace recognises that his father invested considerable care in his upbringing. He acknowledges that his father wanted him to become a good and respectable person rather than simply chase wealth or social prestige. This helps explain why Horace later values moderation, self-awareness and independent judgement.

Therefore, the relationship between Horace and his father in “Satire 1:4” is one of affection, gratitude and moral instruction. Horace's father is represented as an important formative influence who teaches through practical examples. His role helps explain the ethical perspective behind Horace's satire and his emphasis on examining human behaviour.